

Etruscan art

The Etruscans emerged in northern Italy c.700 BCE, between the Geometric and Archaic periods in Greece. Their origins are not clear, but they are thought to have come from Asia Minor, and were eventually assimilated into the Roman Republic in the late fourth century BCE. Etruscan art was strongly linked to religion. Attitudes towards death were similar to those of the Egyptians; they believed life continued after death, but unlike the Egyptians, saw their gods as hostile, and so created art to please them. Tomb walls were decorated with brightly painted murals in a free and fluid style, showing the lives of the (wealthy) deceased.

Although no architecture survives, clay models of Etruscan homes were made as funeral urns. Sarcophagi were also created, often with figures undertaking daily tasks. Figurative sculptures in terracotta and cast bronze display naturalistic gestures, but facial features and hair are rigidly stylized. Though in many ways it resembles the Greek Archaic style, Etruscan sculpture is neither as serene, nor as severe.



Sarcophagus of Seianti Hanunia Tlesnasa, c.145 BCE